3.3 The Council of Ephesus (AD 431): Canonical Perspectives from the Oriental Orthodox Tradition

1. Background and Context

- The Council of Ephesus, convened in AD 431, was the third ecumenical council recognized by the early Christian Church. It occurred amidst theological disputes regarding the nature of Christ and the title of the Virgin Mary. The council aimed to address the controversies surrounding the teachings of Nestorius, Patriarch of Constantinople, who emphasized a duality in Christ's nature and rejected the term "Theotokos" (God-bearer) for Mary.

2. Intentions Behind the Council

The council's primary intentions were:

- To preserve the unity of the Church.
- To clarify and affirm the doctrine of Christ's nature.
- To uphold the title of the Virgin Mary as "Theotokos" against Nestorius' teachings.
- To counter heretical views that threatened the apostolic faith.

3. Summoning the Council

- The council was summoned by Emperor Theodosius II, at the request of Patriarch Cyril of Alexandria, to resolve the theological discord (disharmony) caused by Nestorius' teachings. Letters were sent to key bishops, instructing them to convene at Ephesus, a city known for its deep Marian devotion.

4. Purpose

The purpose of the council was to:

- Examine and adjudicate the teachings of Nestorius.
- Reaffirm the Nicene Creed as the foundation of Christian orthodoxy.
- Establish clarity on the relationship between Christ's divine and human natures.

5. Representation and Venue

- The council took place in Ephesus, at the Church of Mary. It was attended by approximately 200 bishops, primarily from the Eastern Christian world. Notably, Cyril of Alexandria played a leading role, while the absence of significant Western bishops like Pope Celestine I (represented by his legates) highlighted regional tensions.

6. Central Issues Addressed

- The unity of Christ's divine and human natures.
- The legitimacy of the title "Theotokos" for the Virgin Mary.

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- The condemnation of Nestorius and his teachings.
- Preservation of the Nicene Creed without additions or alterations.

7. Canonical Decrees:

- Canons 1-5: Condemned Nestorius, Celestius, and their followers as heretics.
- Canon 6: Mandated deposition or excommunication for those rejecting the council's decrees.
- Canon 7: Prohibited deviations from the Nicene Creed.
- Canon 8: Addressed jurisdictional issues, affirming the independence of the Church in Cyprus from the Bishop of Antioch

8. Key Canons of the Council

The Council of Ephesus issued several significant canons:

Canon 1: Condemnation of Nestorius

- Declared Nestorius' teachings heretical and excommunicated him.
- **Affirm Christ's unified personhood** and anathematize teachings separating His divine and human natures.

Canon 2: Reaffirmation or Affirmation of the Nicene Creed

- Prohibited any alteration or addition to the Nicene Creed, affirming it as the sole statement of Christian faith.
- **Prohibit the introduction of new creeds,** upholding the Nicene Creed as the definitive (absolute, decisive) statement of faith.

Canon 3: Protection of Episcopal Authority or Autonomy of Local Churches

- Forbade bishops from intruding (interfering) into another diocese, emphasizing respect for ecclesiastical boundaries.
- Safeguard diocesan jurisdiction from external interference, promoting harmony.

Canon 4: Condemnation of Heretical Writings

- Ordered the destruction of Nestorian texts and other heretical writings.
- Remove heretical influences, ensuring doctrinal purity.

Canon 5: Unity of Clergy with their Bishops

- Stressed the importance of clergy adhering to their bishops and maintaining church unity.

Canon 6: Reconciliation of Heretics

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- ❖ Provided guidelines for reconciling individuals who repented of heretical beliefs.

9. Significance from the Oriental Orthodox Perspective

The Oriental Orthodox Churches uphold the Council of Ephesus as foundational to their Christological doctrine. Key aspects of its significance include:

- ❖ Affirmation of "Theotokos" as a title for St. Mary, emphasizing the unity of Christ's divine and human natures.
- ❖ Rejection of Nestorianism, which the Oriental Orthodox view as a distortion of apostolic faith.
- ❖ Strengthening ecclesiastical authority and unity in theological matters.
- ❖ Preserving the Nicene Creed as the unaltered statement of orthodox belief.

10.Summary

The Council of Ephesus (AD 431) was a pivotal moment in the history of Christianity. It addressed critical Christological controversies, safeguarded the title of the Virgin Mary as "Theotokos," and upheld the Nicene Creed. From the Oriental Orthodox perspective, its canons and decisions are integral to the faith and doctrine of the Church, ensuring the continuity of apostolic tradition and unity in the body of Christ.

Chapter 4: The Canons of the Holy Fathers and the Canonization of Saints

The Oriental Orthodox Church places great emphasis on the teachings and canons established by **the early Church Fathers,** which **serve as guiding principles** for ecclesiastical governance, doctrinal clarity, and spiritual practice.

Key Canons:

1. **Canon of Apostolic Succession:**
   - ➢ Establishes the unbroken line of **episcopal ordination from the Apostles,** ensuring doctrinal fidelity.

2. **Canon of Ecclesiastical Jurisdiction:**
   - ➢ Defines the territorial and administrative boundaries of bishops and patriarchs.

3. **Canon on Liturgical Practices:**
   - ➢ Mandate's uniformity in liturgical worship, preserving the apostolic tradition.

4. **Canon on Heretical Condemnation:**
   - ➢ Provides guidelines for identifying and addressing heretical teachings within the Church.

5. **Canon of Synodality:**
   - ➢ Emphasizes the importance of councils in resolving doctrinal disputes and maintaining unity.

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The Criteria for Sainthood on the Canonization of Saints

Canonization in the Oriental Orthodox tradition involves recognizing individuals **whose lives exemplify extraordinary holiness, doctrinal fidelity, and martyrdom for the faith**.

Criteria:

1. **Holiness of Life:**
   - The individual must exhibit an exemplary Christian life, characterized by **humility, prayer, and asceticism.**

2. **Orthodox Faith:**
   - Adherence to the teachings of the Church and unwavering (firm, untiring or solid) commitment to apostolic doctrine.

3. **Miracles:**
   - Posthumous[1] miracles attributed to the intercession of the individual serve as evidence of their sanctity.

4. **Martyrdom:**
   - Dying for the faith is considered the highest testament to a saint's commitment to Christ.

5. **Synodal Declaration:**
   - **A Church council** must **formally recognize the individual** as **a saint after thorough investigation and prayer.**

Chapter 5 Canonization of the Holy Scriptures

The Oriental Orthodox Church adheres to a specific canon of Holy Scriptures, which includes both Old and New Testament books, as recognized in the early centuries of Christianity.

Key Decisions:

1. **Old Testament:**
   - Includes 46 books, **encompassing the Septuagint version widely used in early Christianity.**

2. **New Testament:**
   - Comprises 27 books as universally recognized by the early Church.

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[1] **posthumous** refers to events, honors, or recognition occurring **after a saint's death,** such as canonization, the veneration of their relics, or miracles attributed to them.

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3. **Deuterocanonical Books:**
   - Recognized as part of the Old Testament canon and given equal authority.

4. **Apocryphal Writings:**
   - Excluded from the canon but may hold historical or moral value.

Criteria for Canonization:

- Apostolic origin, doctrinal alignment, and widespread liturgical use.

Decisions and Canonization and Church Fathers' Contributions on the Holy Scriptures

The Church Fathers played a significant role in articulating the canon of Scripture and defending it against heretical interpretations.

Contributions:

1. **St. Athanasius of Alexandria:**
   - Provided the first comprehensive list of New Testament books in his Festal Letter (AD 367).
2. **Cyril of Jerusalem:**
   - Advocated the use of canonical books for catechesis and doctrinal instruction.
3. **St. Basil the Great:**
   - Emphasized the importance of Scripture in forming theological foundations.
4. **St. Ephrem the Syrian:**
   - His hymns and writings reinforced the scriptural understanding of Christology.
5. **Synods and Councils:**
   - Decisions at various local synods helped confirm the authenticity and authority of the biblical canon.

The Necessity of a Canon for the Bible

- **The establishment of a biblical canon was vital to <u>maintain doctrinal purity, liturgical consistency, and the spiritual unity of the Church.</u>**

Reasons:

1. Doctrinal Integrity:
   - Prevents the introduction of heretical texts into the Christian tradition.
2. Liturgical Use:
   - Ensures that the Scriptures used in worship align with apostolic teachings.
3. Catechetical Purpose:
   - Provides a definitive source for teaching the faith to new believers.

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4. Unity of the Church: Promotes consistency in doctrine and practice across diverse regions.
5. Defense Against Heresies:
   - Serves as a standard to refute false teachings.

EOTC's Canonization of the Holy Scriptures

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church (EOTC) recognizes a broader canon of Scripture, which includes additional texts not found in other traditions.

Canonical Structure:

1. Old Testament:
   - Includes books such as Enoch, Jubilees (መጽሐፈ ኩፋሌ (Metshafe Kufale)), and 1–4 Esdras[2] (Esdras is called የዕዝራ መጽሀፍት (Ezras).)
2. New Testament:
   - Comprises 27 standard books, along with additional texts like the Book of the Covenant and the Synod of Clement.

Criteria for Inclusion:

Apostolic authorship, alignment with the Church's teachings, and acceptance in liturgical practice.

1. **Liturgical Usage:**
   - All canonical books are used in worship, teaching, and ecclesiastical readings.

References:

1. Athanasius of Alexandria. (1995). The Festal Letters. (T. J. Drake, Trans.). St. Vladimir's Seminary Press.

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[2] Esdras in the canon of scriptures refers to texts associated with Ezra, a scribe and priest significant in Jewish history. The term varies in meaning depending on the biblical tradition:

Hebrew Bible: Refers to the Book of Ezra, a canonical text describing the return of the Jews from Babylonian exile and the rebuilding of the Temple.

Septuagint/Greek Tradition: Includes multiple books:

1 Esdras: A Greek version of Ezra with additional material.
2 Esdras: Often equated with the canonical Ezra-Nehemiah in Greek traditions.
Apocryphal Texts (In some Christian traditions):

3 Esdras and 4 Esdras: Extra-canonical books that include visions and apocalyptic literature.
The term "Esdras" may thus denote canonical, deuterocanonical, or apocryphal works, depending on the religious tradition (e.g., Jewish, Catholic, Orthodox, or Protestant).

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2. Basil the Great. (2011). On the Holy Spirit. (D. Anderson, Trans.). St. Vladimir's Seminary Press.
3. Cyril of Jerusalem. (2012). Catechetical Lectures. (E. Yarnold, Ed. & Trans.). Christian Classics Ethereal Library.
4. Ephrem the Syrian. (1990). Hymns on the Nativity. (S. P. Brock, Ed. & Trans.). St. Vladimir's Seminary Press.
5. Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. (1996). The Canon of the Holy Scriptures. Ethiopian Patriarchal Publication.
6. Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. (2003). Synodos and Didascalia. Addis Ababa: Holy Synod Printing Press.
7. Holy Synod of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. (2006). Fetha Negest (The Law of the Kings). Addis Ababa: Berhanena Selam Printing.
8. John Chrysostom. (1999). Homilies on the Gospel of John. (W. R. Boyd, Ed.). St. Vladimir's Seminary Press.

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